



Leading the charge: Jayson Tatum (0) played a crucial role in Boston Celtics' title-winning run. REUTERS

DOMINANT CELTICS LEAPS ACROSS THE LAKERS

Led by an in-form Jayson Tatum, Boston Celtics **won its 18th championship**, breaking the Los Angeles Lakers' previous record.

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Growing up, Jayson Tatum was a devoted fan of the Los Angeles Lakers and admired Kobe Bryant deeply.

He was tantalisingly close to playing for his favourite team when the Lakers had the chance to draft him in 2017.

"It was crazy that the Lakers had the second pick, and I was so close to a dream come true. But it was like they didn't want anything to do with me at the time," Tatum told *ESPN* in a 2022 interview.

It was poetic irony that he played a crucial role in the Boston Celtics' championship run this season, helping the team surpass the Lakers' all-time tally by winning it for a record 18th time.

Celtics' dominant season

The Celtics had an exceptional season. Under the guidance of head coach Joe Mazzulla, who has been at the helm since 2022, it clinched the top spot in both the Atlantic Division and the Eastern Conference before entering the Playoffs.

This marked the seventh time it topped both division and conference standings. In the previous six instances — 1973-74, 1975-76, 1980-81, 1983-84, 1985-86, and 2007-08 — the team lifted the Larry O'Brien Championship trophy.